Media Spokesperson Policy

Policy Summary & Knowledge Check

Authority	Board of Directors
Date Ratified	December 10, 2025
Next Review Date	December 2028
Previous Amendments	February 2, 2024; November 6, 2020; September 1, 2011
Related Document(s)	Media Spokesperson Procedure

Policy Summary

This policy provides guidelines for staff conduct in relation to media. It applies to part-time and full-time USC employees (including Executives, AVPs, Coordinators, Interns, and the Board of Directors) but does not restrict the conduct of Gazette staff. It defines internal versus external media and sets out who is authorized to speak to media on the USC's behalf — the President, Vice-Presidents within their portfolios, the Senior Manager, Communications, and the Board of Directors Chairperson — while restricting general management and staff from providing attributable quotes without authorization.

Key Takeaways

- Applies to part-time (including AVPs, Coordinators, and Interns) and full-time USC employees (including Executives and the Board of Directors); it does not restrict the conduct of Gazette staff.
- "Internal Media" means the Gazette, CHRW, Western News, and the Alumni Gazette; "External Media" means all other media outlets.
- The President is authorized to speak to media on all matters, and as common practice may refer Vice-President portfolio matters to the relevant VP, or certain corporate matters to the Senior Manager, Communications.
- Vice-Presidents are authorized to speak on matters within their portfolio's mandate, and may authorize volunteers within their portfolio, such as Associates and Coordinators, to speak on their behalf.
- The President authorizes the Senior Manager, Communications to speak on behalf of the organization when requested or when a matter falls outside the President's purview (for example, Elections).
- Management and staff are not authorized as spokespeople and must not provide attributable quotes to media unless authorization has been received from the President or the Senior Manager, Communications; they may act as background resources if requested by the President.
- The Board of Directors Chairperson is authorized to speak to media on matters within their mandate as outlined in By-law 1; the Media Spokesperson Procedure does not apply to the Chairperson.
- For tracking purposes, authorized spokespeople must inform the Senior Manager, Communications when they've been contacted by media, to help schedule interviews.

Knowledge Check

4 situational questions to check understanding of this policy. An answer key follows on the next page.

Q1. A staff member who is not an authorized spokesperson is contacted directly by an external reporter for a quote. What should they do?

A. Provide the quote, since they know the subject well.

B. Decline to provide an attributable quote unless authorization has been received from the President or Senior Manager, Communications.

C. Refer the reporter to the Gazette instead.

D. Give a quote but ask to remain anonymous.

Q2. A Vice-President wants a Coordinator within their own portfolio to speak to media on their behalf. Is this permitted?

A. Only for internal media outlets.

B. No, only the President can authorize this.

C. Yes — Vice-Presidents may authorize volunteers within their portfolio, such as Associates and Coordinators, to speak on their behalf.

D. Only with Board of Directors approval.

Q3. Which of the following is considered "Internal Media" under this policy?

A. Any USC-run social media account.

B. Local London television news.

C. A national newspaper.

D. The Gazette, CHRW, Western News, or the Alumni Gazette.

Q4. A media matter falls outside the President's purview, such as a matter related to Elections. Who may the President authorize to speak on the organization's behalf?

A. The Senior Manager, Communications.

B. The Board of Directors Chairperson.

C. The Gazette editor.

D. Any available staff member.

Answer Key

Q1: B — Section 3.3.2 states management and staff are not authorized as spokespeople and shall not provide attributable quotes without authorization from the President or Senior Manager, Communications.

Q2: C — Section 3.2.1.1 states Vice-Presidents may authorize volunteers within their portfolio to speak on their behalf.

Q3: D — Section 2.1 defines Internal Media as the Gazette, CHRW, Western News, and the Alumni Gazette.

Q4: A — Section 3.3.1 states the President authorizes the Senior Manager, Communications to speak on behalf of the organization when a matter falls outside the President's purview.